
ECON 312 — Intermediate Microeconomics

Fall 2026

Instructor: Prof. Peter Doe

Location: Van Zoeren Hall 298

Email: doe42@hope.edu

Meetings: MWF 1:00–1:50PM

Office: Van Zoeren Hall 165A

Credit Hours: 3.0

Office Hours My office is Van Zoeren Hall 165A, and my office hours are **by appointment here**. All office hours are held **in person in my office** unless you request Zoom. If you are struggling in this course, I highly recommend visiting me.



Scan to book

Course Description & Preparation

Course Description (From the course catalog) Intermediate-level treatment of microeconomics concerned primarily with resource allocation decisions under various product and resource market conditions. Implications for business and public policy are emphasized. Students may take BUS 223 or ECON 223 either prior to enrollment in or concurrently with this class.

Course Description (My version) This course develops the mathematical foundation of markets. We begin with a two-part analysis of a consumer: the maximization problem she faces and the effects of changing prices and incomes. We then turn to the other side of the market and examine how sellers maximize profit. Putting these together, we study how the number and size of sellers affects the operation of the market and the distribution of the gains from trade. Finally, we examine the welfare implications of using prices to allocate goods.

Required Resources & Materials The textbook for this course is the second edition of Varian and Melitz' *Intermediate Microeconomics with Calculus*. Make sure you get the **WITH CALCULUS** version! These same authors have a non-calculus (and hence less exciting) version of this same book.

You do *not* need to purchase any other material, such as online homework access. All homeworks and reading quizzes are produced “in-house.”

Method/Mode of Instruction This course is taught **in person** with the exception of two scheduled virtual classes.

Student Learning Outcomes This course contributes to the following learning outcomes associated with the Economics major:

1. *Critical Thinking*: Enhanced ability to integrate (a) applied and theoretical experiences, and (b) a deep understanding of the content in economics and business, in analytical, problem-solving

and creative activities.

4. *Ability to use economic theory*: The ability to use economic theory to analyze economic phenomena.

Evaluation

Grading Assignment grades will be weighted as follows:

Category	Weight
Professionalism	10%
Problem Sets	10%
Research Proposals	10%
First Midterm	6%
Second Midterm	16%
Third Midterm	12%
Fourth Midterm	12%
Final Exam	24%
Total	100%

Letter grades are assigned as follows:

Grade	Cutoff	Grade	Cutoff
A	≥ 93	C	≥ 73
A-	≥ 90	C-	≥ 70
B+	≥ 87	D+	≥ 67
B	≥ 83	D	≥ 63
B-	≥ 80	D-	≥ 60
C+	≥ 77	F	< 60

All grades except professionalism will be updated in Moodle. Moodle does not apply these category weights, so the total it displays is not your actual grade. I do not round grades up.

Professionalism Presenting oneself in a professional manner is fundamental to success in all academic disciplines. To encourage this, I award points across the three **P.I.E.** categories: preparation, initiative, and engagement:

1. **Preparation:** You complete the daily reading quizzes and the syllabus quiz. Each quiz completed on time and correctly contributes 1 point.
2. **Initiative:** You take the first step, whether in arranging a meeting or in asking for particular class materials. Communications with me that demonstrate this will be awarded 1 or 2 points.
3. **Engagement:** You ask and answer relevant questions in class. Points are awarded for each class according to the following scale:

Level of Question or Answer	Points
Attendance only	1
Any quality	2
Excellent	3
Outstanding	4

Your grade for the professionalism category of this course will be determined relative to the scores of your peers. I will sum your points across all three categories to get your *raw score*. I will then compute a *z-score* for each student.¹ Students with a *z-score* of 0 will receive 80% of the grade for the professionalism category. (*Layman's terms: the average raw score gets 8 out of 10 points.*) Each standard deviation above or below the mean is worth 20% of the professionalism grade. (*Layman's terms: In a class of 20 students, 3 will earn a 100% or greater, while 3 will earn a 60% or lower.*) I will keep a running document with your professionalism score. You may ask me at any time to see your current score.

Additionally, I will grant four *awards* per exam based upon your professionalism categories. Each award is worth 2 points on that exam. In the event of a tie, every student tied for an award receives it.

1. *Captain Obvious*: Most classes with a 2 or higher score.
2. *General Interesting*: Most classes with a 3 or higher score.
3. *President Prepared*: Most completed reading quizzes.
4. *Extra-Credit Cadet*: Most points in the *initiative* category.

Problem Sets Problem sets are assigned on Wednesdays and due the following Wednesday at the start of class, completed in teams (assigned in the first week). The lone exception is the syllabus quiz at the end of this syllabus, which you complete individually and hand in (hard copy) on the **first Friday of the semester**. Each set is graded on a written team submission *and* a live in-class oral examination by your peers, in which teams rotate through presenter, examiner, and judge roles. *Full mechanics—roles, format, and the weekly flow—are in the separate **Problem Sets** handout on Moodle.*

Research Proposals Foundational to becoming an economist is learning to ask the right *kinds* of research questions. Prior to each exam, your team submits three proposals related to the exam content—one each in the *Foundational*, *Extension*, and *Application* categories. Each proposal has a written component (via Moodle) and a short three-slide lightning presentation. *Full instructions, the required components for each category, and the rubric are in the separate **Research Proposals** handout on Moodle.*

Exams There will be four midterm exams. If you have a schedule conflict with a midterm exam, we can work out an alternate exam time. If no alternate time is reasonable, then the weight on your final exam will be increased to compensate for the missed midterm examination. *All arrangements (either*

¹This is a statistical way of describing a raw score relative to the other raw scores.

for a different time or for shifting weight to the final) must be made **before** the originally scheduled exam. Additionally, this policy may only be used on one exam.

Date	Exam	Chapters (tentative)
Monday, September 21	Exam 1 — Basic Consumers	2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7
Wednesday, October 14	Exam 2 — Comparative Statics	8, 9, 14, 10, 15
Monday, November 2	Exam 3 — The Firm	19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24
Wednesday, November 18	Exam 4 — On the Origin of Prices	16, 25, 28 + Two-Sided Matching
Wednesday, December 16	Final Exam (12:30–2:30PM)	35, 36, 32, 34 + cumulative

My Policies

Exam Policies You are allowed to bring in a *hand-written* study guide for each exam. It must be on a 3 × 5 notecard. For the final, you are allowed five notecards, each of which must be newly written for the final—you may not reuse your midterm cards.

Any other form of assistance on an exam (other kinds of notes, the internet, AI, passing notes, hacking my computer, etc.) is a violation of academic honesty. Cheating on an exam may result in receiving a zero for that exam and/or failing the class.

Typically, the first 20 points on an exam are given “for free.” I reserve the right to award negative points for answers that demonstrate that you do not know what you do not know.

Generative AI “With great power comes great responsibility.” – *Uncle Ben*

“... and sometimes great nonsense” – *ChatGPT*

You may absolutely use AI tools for **out-of-class assignments**; in-class assignments are covered in the Exam Policies section. For your problem sets and research proposals, I expect them to be polished and immaculate. In the same way that spelling errors are a sign of inattentiveness rather than a foible in the age of spellcheck, clumsily formatted documents receive no compassion when an LLM sits by your side. You can (and are encouraged to) use these tools to learn the course material as well. However, *you* (the human...) are responsible for anything submitted to me. You must master the content—Claude can’t do that for you! 90% of your grade depends on *in-class* assignments. My heart is not inclined to show mercy to students who AI their way through the homework and somehow run aground on the midterm.

Technology In Class Our classroom is a **no screen zone**—technology use carries *negative externalities*, and a phone distracts your neighbors as much as you. *Each violation costs 1 percentage point off your final grade in the course*—not off a single assignment, and there is *no cap* on the number of violations. You may request an exemption by email (and must receive approval) for a compelling reason, such as a stylus tablet for notes or a DAR accommodation.

Grade Disputes If you wish to dispute a grade, you must do so within 3 class days of receiving the grade. Keeping short accounts is an important life skill—just as I promptly return your exams, I expect you to read the markup in a timely manner.

Disclaimer This syllabus is subject to change. Any updates will be communicated via email and/or Moodle.

Institutional Policies

Hope College Policies Standard college policies—academic assistance, academic honesty, accommodations, attendance, inclement weather, safety, short-term absence, and student complaints—apply to this course. They are collected on the separate **Hope College Policies** sheet distributed alongside this syllabus and posted on Moodle.

Tentative Schedule A week-by-week schedule of topics, readings, and exam dates is tentative and subject to change. It is provided on the separate **Tentative Schedule** handout distributed alongside this syllabus and posted on Moodle.

Syllabus Quiz

Name: _____

Date: _____

Answer each question below. Every answer can be found directly in the text of this syllabus. This quiz is due **at the start of class** on the first Friday of the semester (Friday, September 4). Correctly answering all four questions is worth 1 point toward your Preparation score.

1. My office hours are best described as:

- (a) Walk-in only, weekday mornings, no appointment needed.
- (b) By appointment, and always held over Zoom.
- (c) By appointment via the scheduling link, in person in Van Zoeren Hall 165A unless you request Zoom.
- (d) Not offered; all questions must be handled by email.

2. Your Professionalism grade is determined by:

- (a) Your raw P.I.E. score converted to a z-score relative to your peers.
- (b) The instructor's subjective impression of your attitude.
- (c) A flat 10% awarded to every student who attends regularly.
- (d) Your performance on the syllabus quiz alone.

3. The classroom's Technology In Class policy is best described as:

- (a) Unrestricted, since this is a college class.
- (b) Laptops permitted, phones prohibited.
- (c) Screens permitted only during exams.
- (d) A no-screen zone, with each violation costing 1 percentage point off your final grade in the course.

4. Regarding problem sets, this course requires that they be:

- (a) Completed individually and submitted online through MindTap.
- (b) Completed in teams and defended in a live in-class oral examination by your peers.
- (c) Completed in teams, with your lowest three grades dropped.
- (d) Optional practice with no bearing on your grade.